

NMEC595 - Research Methodology

Lecture 2a: Types of Research Articles and Journal Metrics

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Learning goals

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- classify common scholarly output types and match them to research intent
- identify what each output type usually contains (claims, evidence, structure)
- interpret common journal metrics, quartile rankings, and indexing databases
- understand Scopus, Web of Science (SCI/SCIE), and their selection criteria
- choose venues using metrics and scope-fit, editorial practice, and ethics
- recognize ethical pitfalls and gaming behaviors in publication systems

Agenda

- ➊ Output types: journal articles, conference papers, extended abstracts
- ➋ Evidence expectations and structure
- ➌ Journal metrics (JIF, CiteScore, SJR, SNIP, h-index, Eigenfactor)
- ➍ Quartile rankings (Q1, Q2, Q3, Q4) and their interpretation
- ➎ Indexing databases: Scopus vs Web of Science (SCI/SCIE)
- ➏ Conference indicators (acceptance rate, selectivity, proceedings, indexing)
- ➐ How to interpret metrics and indicators safely
- ➑ A practical decision checklist

Big picture

- Output type influences: claim, evidence, length, and review criteria
- Metrics and indicators influence: visibility and evaluation
- Indexing determines discoverability and perceived prestige

A practical taxonomy of scholarly research outputs

- **Journal articles**
 - original research
 - review and survey
 - methods, software, and data papers
 - perspectives, commentaries, letters
- **Conference papers**
- **Extended abstracts**
- **Preprints** (emerging format for rapid dissemination)

Original research article

Purpose: introduce a new contribution with evidence.

- Typical claims: new theory, new method, new dataset, new insight
- Evidence: experiments, proofs, simulations, ablations, benchmarks
- Review focus: novelty, correctness, rigor, transparency
- Typical length: 8,000–15,000 words plus figures and supplementary materials

Example: A paper presenting a new fatigue life prediction model for additively manufactured Ti-6Al-4V, validated against strain-controlled fatigue tests and finite element simulations of notched specimens under variable-amplitude loading.

Review article (narrative review)

Purpose: synthesize literature and identify gaps.

- Strength: author organizes, interprets, and critically discusses the state of a field
- Scope: defined by author's judgment and experience
- Risk: selection bias if scope and inclusion criteria are not explicit
- Typical length: 8,000–20,000 words (often longest format)

Example: A review titled "Advances in Condition Monitoring of Rotating Machinery" surveys 250+ papers on vibration analysis, acoustic emission, oil debris analysis, and model-based diagnostics, and highlights open problems in fault detection under variable-speed conditions.

Methods paper

Purpose: introduce a reusable method with sufficient detail for adoption.

- Content: method derivation or algorithm, computational complexity analysis, limitations, practical guidance
- Evidence: validation on multiple datasets/structures, parametric studies, sensitivity to various factors.
- Audience: researchers who will reuse or extend the method
- Review standard: focus on clarity, generality, and evidence of utility

Example: A methods paper proposing a new reduced-order modeling technique for nonlinear vibration of turbine blades, with derivation, error analysis relative to full finite-element models, and demonstrations on several blade geometries and loading conditions.

Software paper

Purpose: present a tool that enables research workflows.

- Contribution: design decisions, implementation quality, documentation, and usability
- Evidence: verification tests, benchmarks, real use cases, user feedback (if available)
- Requirements: clear license (e.g., MIT, GPL), versioning, archival reference (Zenodo or institutional repository with DOI)
- Publication venues: software-focused or application-oriented engineering journals

Example: A software paper introducing an open-source Python toolbox for automated fatigue analysis of welded joints, including interfaces to commercial FE packages, verification against standard design curves (IIW), and case studies on ship structures and crane girders.

Data Descriptor (Dataset Paper): Key Points

Purpose: Make generated datasets easy to find, use, and cite.

- Describe how data was collected and organized
- Show data quality (checks, completeness, bias)
- State access rules (open license, e.g., CC-BY)
- Publish in data journals or relevant engineering journals

Example: Mechanical MNIST Dataset

Case study / application paper

Purpose: demonstrate a method in a realistic setting and extract generalizable lessons.

- Strong when: evaluation is credible (controls, baselines), context is detailed, and transferable lessons exist
- Weak when: no comparisons, no uncertainty analysis, claims overgeneralize beyond the context
- Typical length: 5,000–10,000 words

Example: A case study on optimizing an automotive assembly line using discrete-event simulation and line balancing algorithms, comparing throughput, WIP, and utilization before and after redesign, and discussing how the approach can generalize to other high-volume manufacturing systems.

Perspective / viewpoint / opinion

Purpose: argue for a direction, framework, or agenda in a field.

- Evidence: selective but fair; counter-literature and alternative views must be acknowledged
- Authority: typically invited; sometimes open to submissions
- Review focus: coherence, plausibility, originality of insight, and value to the community
- Tone: argumentative but evidence-grounded

Example: A perspective titled “Towards Truly Integrated Digital Twins for Mechanical Systems” arguing for standardized interfaces between CAD, CAE, sensor data, and control systems, discussing challenges in validation and lifecycle updating for complex assets like wind turbines or gas turbines.

Commentary, editorial, and letter

- **Commentary:** response to a published work or thematic issue; typically 1,000–3,000 words
- **Editorial:** usually invited; sets venue direction, announces special issues, or comments on field developments
- **Letter / response:** critique, correction, clarification, or extension of a prior paper (often < 500 words)

Example: A letter to a tribology journal pointing out that a published friction coefficient model for a particular lubricant–surface pair neglects mixed lubrication effects, with recalculated results suggesting narrower applicability.

Preprints: emerging format

Purpose: rapid dissemination before peer review; claim priority.

- Platforms: arXiv (engineering), institutional repositories
- Advantages: immediate visibility, community feedback, priority timestamp
- Risks: not peer-reviewed (quality varies), potential misuse of unvetted results by industry or media
- Best practice: clearly label as preprint, update with peer-reviewed version link

Example: A preprint on a novel topology optimization algorithm for lightweight aircraft brackets is posted on arXiv and later revised after feedback from mechanical design researchers before submission to a journal.

Conference paper: what it is

Purpose: rapid dissemination to an active research community with quick feedback loop.

- peer-reviewed on a shorter timeline (typically 2–4 months vs 4–12 months for journals)
- emphasizes novelty and relevance to the community
- often associated with an oral or poster presentation at the venue
- culture varies: many mechanical engineering subfields (e.g., manufacturing, design, dynamics) value both ASME/IEEE conferences and journals

Example: An ASME conference paper on a new vibration-based method for detecting cracks in rotating shafts presents the core algorithm and experimental validation on a test rig; a later journal version adds uncertainty quantification and additional test cases.

Conference paper: characteristics

- length: venue-dependent, commonly 6–10 pages including references
- evidence: core results demonstrated convincingly, but exhaustive validation often deferred to extended journal versions
- output: archival (indexed, citable DOI) or non-archival (presentation-only)
- review: single-blind or double-blind depending on society and conference

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Key idea: complete enough to stand alone and judge novelty, but not always exhaustive in validation.

Extended abstract: what it is

Purpose: communicate the core idea with minimal overhead; often for early-stage work or community discussion.

- common in workshops, symposia, and special sessions
- may be archival (short proceedings) or non-archival
- emphasis on concept, not completeness of evidence
- typical length: 2–4 pages

Example: An extended abstract describing preliminary CFD results for a novel micro-channel heat sink geometry, with a single parametric sweep and qualitative comparison to a baseline design, intended to solicit feedback before full optimization and experimentation.

Extended abstract: characteristics

- length: short format (2–4 pages, sometimes 1 page)
- content: clear problem statement, approach motivation, key result claim, and preliminary evidence
- validation: limited, often a single prototype, simulation case, or test condition
- audience: peers interested in the topic; less formal than full conference papers

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- audience: peers interested in the topic; less formal than full conference papers

Key idea: emphasis is on communicating the idea and inviting discussion, not demonstrating full rigor.

From abstract to conference to journal

A common progression:

- 1 **Extended abstract** (idea disclosure, early CFD/FEA results, feedback at workshop)
- 2 **Conference paper** (core results with key experiments or simulations; 6–10 pages)
- 3 **Journal article** (expanded evidence, additional case studies, uncertainty analysis; 15–25 pages)

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- 1 **Extended abstract** (idea disclosure, early CFD/FEA results, feedback at workshop)
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- 3 **Journal article** (expanded evidence, additional case studies, uncertainty analysis; 15–25 pages)

Important rule: journal submission needs substantial new material (often $\geq 30\%$ new content). **Always disclose** prior conference versions and clearly describe what is new.

Example: An ASME MSEC paper on tool wear monitoring in milling is extended into a journal paper by adding more machining conditions, different workpiece materials, a statistical uncertainty analysis, and an industrial case study.

What reviewers usually check

- **Fit:** scope match and audience match; does the work align with the journal or conference scope?
- **Novelty:** contribution beyond prior art (e.g., new model, improved efficiency, new mechanism)
- **Correctness:** theory (derivations), experiments (test rig design, calibration), simulations (mesh, BCs), statistics (appropriate tests)
- **Rigor:** baselines, controls, sensitivity checks, uncertainty quantification (e.g., error bars for strain measurements)
- **Transparency:** data/code availability (e.g., experimental datasets, CAD/mesh files), reproducibility notes, limitations discussed
- **Ethics:** authorship attribution, conflict of interest disclosure (e.g., industrial sponsorship), safety and compliance (pressure vessels, human subjects in ergonomics studies)

Typical section templates by output type

Type	Typical structure
Journal (research)	Abstract, Intro, Literature Review, Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusion
Methods	Problem, Method Description, Theory/Derivation, Validation, Limitations, Usage Guidance
Software	Motivation, Design Rationale, Architecture, Implementation, Tests, Examples, Availability
Dataset	Motivation, Data Collection Protocol, Schema, Quality & Bias Analysis, Access/License
Conference paper	Abstract, Intro, Methods, Results, Discussion, Future Work
Extended abstract	Problem, Approach, Preliminary Results, Planned Work
Systematic review	Scope/Protocol, Search Strategy, Inclusion Criteria, Quality Assessment, Synthesis

Evidence standards by output type

Type	Evidence standard
Original research	Multiple experiments/structures, statistical analysis, comparison to standards (e.g., ASME, ISO)
Methods paper	Validation on diverse cases (geometries, loads), convergence and error analysis, reproducibility
Software paper	Verification against analytical solutions/benchmarks, regression tests, realistic application examples
Dataset paper	Description of measurement setup, sensor calibration, noise analysis, coverage and bias checks
Systematic review	Predefined protocol, transparent inclusion/exclusion criteria, critical appraisal of study quality
Conference paper	Convincing core results, basic comparison to existing approaches, clear limitations
Extended abstract	Minimal preliminary evidence showing feasibility or potential benefit

Why metrics exist (and why they fail)

- Metrics summarize citation behavior and attention patterns based on historical data
- Citations depend on field size, citation culture, article type (reviews vs research), and typical project timescales
- A single number cannot measure rigor, reproducibility, industrial relevance, or impact
- Risk: perverse incentive to chase metrics instead of solving meaningful problems

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“When a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure” – Goodhart’s Law

Journal Impact Factor (JIF): the idea

- **Formula:** $JIF(\text{year } Y) = (\text{citations in } Y \text{ to articles in } Y-1 \text{ and } Y-2) / (\text{citable items in } Y-1 \text{ and } Y-2)$
- Typical range in mechanical engineering: $\approx 0.5\text{--}5$ for many field-specific journals; higher for broad, high-impact venues
- Influenced by: review articles, editorial policies, and self-citation practices
- Published by Clarivate Analytics in *Journal Citation Reports (JCR)*

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Critical caveat: JIF is a journal-level average. It does not tell you whether a specific paper on gear dynamics or heat exchangers is high quality.

Fact: A niche mechanical journal on pump design may have $\text{JIF} \approx 0.7$ yet publish work that becomes a standard design reference in industry for decades.

JIF pitfalls and gaming

- **Citation inflation:** editors pushing authors to cite previous articles from the same journal
- **Article type bias:** review papers on broad mechanical engineering topics attract far more citations than narrow experimental studies
- **Field bias:** mechanical engineering journals often have lower JIFs than biomedical or materials journals due to different citation cultures
- **Self-citation:** journals inflate JIF by citing their own articles; monitored by Clarivate

Example: In 2023, Clarivate suppressed JIF for several journals due to excessive self-citation and citation stacking.

CiteScore

- **Formula:** $\text{CiteScore} = (\text{number of citations in year } Y \text{ to items published in } Y-3, Y-2, Y-1, Y) \text{ divided by } (\text{number of items published in } Y-3, Y-2, Y-1, Y)$
- Uses a four-year citation window, which is longer than the Journal Impact Factor (two years)
- Includes conference papers and selected non-journal materials indexed by Scopus
- Typical values for mechanical engineering journals range from 1 to 8
- Provided by Elsevier through Scopus metrics

Advantage: Suited for disciplines with longer research and application cycles.

Limitation: Results can depend on database scope and inclusion of non-journal content.

SJR, SNIP, Eigenfactor: what they try to fix

- **SJR (Scimago Journal Rank):** assigns higher weight to citations from more influential journals, not all citations are counted equally. SJR uses a network algorithm similar to PageRank and is based on Scopus data. This approach attempts to measure both the quantity and quality of citations, so that citations from highly regarded journals contribute more to a journal's score.
- **SNIP (Source Normalized Impact per Paper):** adjusts for differences in citation practices between fields. Some areas of mechanical engineering, such as thermofluids, naturally have higher citation rates than others, such as structural mechanics. SNIP enables fairer comparison by normalizing for these field-specific differences, allowing for more meaningful evaluation across subfields.

Journal Quartiles

Quartile rankings classify journals in a subject category into four equal groups, based on a chosen impact metric (such as Impact Factor, CiteScore, or SJR):

- **Q1 (Top 25%):** Journals in the top quartile; these are regarded as the most prestigious and influential in the field.
- **Q2 (25–50%):** Journals in the second quartile; high-quality journals with significant impact and visibility.
- **Q3 (50–75%):** Journals in the third quartile; moderate-impact journals that are well-established but less influential than Q1 or Q2.
- **Q4 (75–100%):** Journals in the bottom quartile; these are lower-ranked, sometimes newer or more specialized journals.

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Key point: Quartile rankings are always **specific to each subject category**. A journal may be Q1 in “Mechanical Engineering” but Q2 or Q3 in another category, such as “Materials Science,” depending on its relative performance among journals in each group.

Using Quartiles: Guidance and Cautions

When useful:

- Quick check of journal standing within a subject area
- Comparison across journals in the same category
- Required by institutions for promotions or grants (e.g., Q1/Q2)

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Limitations:

- Quartile $\neq$ paper quality; strong papers appear in Q3/Q4, and vice versa
- Categories differ across databases (Scopus vs JCR)
- Smaller fields make Q1 status easier to attain
- Metrics can be manipulated (e.g., via self-citation)
- Rankings change yearly with citation updates

What is journal indexing and why it matters

Indexing means a journal's articles are systematically cataloged in a searchable database.

- **Visibility:** Indexed journals are discoverable by researchers worldwide
- **Credibility:** Indexing in selective databases signals quality control
- **Career impact:** Many institutions require Scopus or SCI indexing for promotion
- **Citation tracking:** Indexed journals contribute to citation metrics (h-index, JIF)

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Key databases for mechanical engineering:

- **Scopus** (Elsevier): broadest coverage, includes conferences
- **Web of Science (WoS)** — includes **SCI**, **SCIE** (Clarivate): more selective, prestige-focused
- **Ei Compendex:** engineering-specific database

Scopus: overview and coverage

Scopus (owned by Elsevier) is the largest abstract and citation database:

- **Coverage:** > 27,000 journals, including conferences, books, and trade publications
- **Scope:** Multidisciplinary (STM + social sciences + humanities)
- **Selection criteria:** Peer review, regular publication, English abstracts, ethical standards (COPE compliance)
- **Mechanical engineering:** Strong coverage of ASME, IEEE, SAE, Springer, Elsevier journals
- **Metrics:** CiteScore, SJR, SNIP calculated from Scopus data

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Strengths:

- Broader coverage (more journals than WoS)
- Includes non-English journals with English abstracts
- Better coverage of Asian and European journals

Web of Science (WoS): SCI and SCIE

Web of Science is a selective citation index maintained by Clarivate Analytics, widely used for academic evaluation and journal ranking.

- **SCI (Science Citation Index):** The original core index, launched in 1964, includes $\approx 3,900$ elite journals in science and engineering. Highly selective—only the most influential journals are included.
- **SCIE (Science Citation Index Expanded):** A broader index that includes all SCI journals and $\approx 9,500+$ additional high-quality journals. Covers a wider range of scientific disciplines and emerging fields.

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Selection criteria: Inclusion in SCI or SCIE requires rigorous standards for editorial quality, peer-review, international diversity, citation performance, ethical publishing, and timely publication.

WoS Metrics and Mechanical Engineering Examples

Associated Metric: The Journal Impact Factor (JIF), published in the Journal Citation Reports (JCR), is derived from Web of Science data and widely used for journal evaluation.

- **Core SCI mechanical engineering journals:**

- *ASME Journal of Mechanical Design*
- *International Journal of Heat and Mass Transfer*
- *Tribology International*

- **SCIE specialized journals:**

- *Journal of Sound and Vibration*
- *Mechanism and Machine Theory*
- *Mechanical Systems and Signal Processing*

How to verify if a journal is indexed

Step-by-step verification:

- 1 **Scopus:** Visit scopus.com/sources → "Source List" → search journal title → check status (Active = indexed)
- 2 **Web of Science (SCIE):** Access Web of Science "Master Journal List" at mjl.clarivate.com → search journal → check if indexed in SCIE or SCI
- 3 **SCImago:** Visit scimagojr.com → search journal → check indexing status, quartile, and SJR
- 4 **Journal website:** Look for indexing logos or "About" page listings (verify independently—some journals falsely claim indexing)

Warning: Predatory journals often falsely claim Scopus or SCI indexing. Always verify directly through official database websites. Check Beall's List for known predatory publishers.

Other important engineering databases

Beyond Scopus and WoS, mechanical engineers should know:

- **Ei Compendex:** Engineering-specific database (Elsevier), covers > 5,000 journals + conferences
 - Strong in mechanical, civil, electrical, chemical engineering
 - Many ASME and IEEE publications indexed here
 - Established 1884, originally "Engineering Index"
- **Google Scholar:** Free, very broad coverage (includes preprints, theses, reports)
 - Useful for comprehensive searches but no quality filter
 - h-index and citation counts available for authors
- **IEEE Xplore:** IEEE and IET publications (electrical + mechanical systems)
- **PubMed:** Biomedical focus (less relevant for pure ME, useful for biomechanics)

h-index and Related Metrics

- **h-index:** A researcher has h -index = h if h of their papers have at least h citations each. This single number aims to capture both productivity (number of papers) and scholarly impact (citations received).
- **Limitations:** The h -index varies greatly by research field and typically increases with career length. It does not distinguish between author positions (first author, last author) or individual contribution to multi-author papers.
- **Related metrics:**
 - **g-index:** Gives extra weight to highly-cited papers (sum of top g papers' citations is at least g^2).
 - **i10-index:** Counts the number of papers with at least 10 citations each (used by Google Scholar).
 - **m-quotient:** Normalizes the h -index by dividing by the number of years since the researcher's first publication, allowing for fairer comparison across career stages.

Alternative metrics and cautions

- **Altmetrics:** mentions of mechanical engineering work in standards, patents, technical reports, and social media
- **F1000Prime:** expert ratings (manually curated; subject to selection bias)
- **Usage metrics:** downloads of design guidelines or software tools; may indicate industrial interest
- All such metrics can be noisy, biased toward popular topics (e.g., renewable energy, electric vehicles), and vulnerable to manipulation

Better evaluation: read the work, assess methods and validation, and consider real engineering impact (e.g., adopted in ASME standards, ISO codes, or industry design practices).

Conference indicators: what to look at

Conference evaluation often uses operational indicators:

- **Acceptance rate:** accepted / submitted (selectivity proxy; many good mechanical conferences are in the 20–40% range)
- **Review model:** single-blind, double-blind, or editorially reviewed
- **Proceedings status:** archival (indexed, citable DOI) vs non-archival
- **Indexing:** whether proceedings are indexed in engineering databases (e.g., Scopus, Web of Science, Ei Compendex)
- **Presentation type:** oral vs poster vs invited; meaning varies by conference

Acceptance rate: how to interpret

- Lower acceptance rate (e.g., 20–30%) can indicate selectivity, but does not guarantee high methodological rigor
- Acceptance rate depends on submission volume, topic breadth, and review capacity
- Mid-tier conferences with 40–60% acceptance may still be excellent venues in specialized mechanical engineering niches
- Gaming risk: conferences inflate submission totals to artificially lower acceptance rate

Compare acceptance rates within similar mechanical engineering communities (e.g., manufacturing vs thermal-fluids vs dynamics), not across disciplines.

Proceedings and archival value

- **Archival proceedings:** stable, citable record (often via ASME, IEEE, SAE, or major publishers like Springer)
- **Non-archival events:** good for community building and feedback, but less useful as permanent references
- In mechanical engineering, many key ideas appear first in conference proceedings and later in extended journal articles
- Disciplinary variation: mechanical design, manufacturing, and dynamics communities value both conferences and journals

Example: A new method for cutting force prediction might first appear at an ASME manufacturing conference (MSEC) and later in a journal like Journal of Manufacturing Processes or International Journal of Machine Tools and Manufacture with extended validation.

Conference prestige vs citation behavior

- Citation rates for mechanical engineering conferences are typically lower than in some AI/CS venues, but conference papers can still be influential
- Industrial practitioners may attend conferences and apply methods without generating many citations
- Some subfields (e.g., manufacturing science, rotor dynamics, vehicle systems) treat certain conferences as key community events
- Prestige is relative: top-tier venue in one subfield may be unknown outside

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Judge conferences by community reputation, standing organizers (ASME, IEEE, SAE committees), and proceedings quality, not only citations.

Common conference red flags

- Very broad scope with no clear mechanical engineering focus (“all topics in engineering and science”)
- Aggressive spam invitations unrelated to your specialization
- Vague or inconsistent statements about indexing and proceedings publisher
- No recognizable society backing (e.g., not associated with ASME, IEEE, SAE, or established publishers)
- Very short review timelines that are unrealistic for technical mechanical papers (e.g., 2-week review for 500 papers)
- High submission fees (\$500+) unrelated to publication costs

Practical check: Ask colleagues whether they recognize the conference; inspect previous years' programs, publishers (IEEE, ASME, Springer), and check Beall's List for predatory venues.

Metric and indicator pitfalls

- **Cross-field comparison:** comparing a mechanical journal's JIF directly with a biomedical journal's JIF is misleading (use SNIP for field normalization)
- **Venue-level vs article-level:** good and bad papers exist in every journal or conference, regardless of metric
- **Ignoring article type:** review papers in mechanical engineering (e.g., on wind turbine design, additive manufacturing) accumulate citations 2–5× faster than narrow experimental studies
- **Gaming risk:** excessive self-citation and citation cartels can distort metrics without improving actual engineering practice
- **Incentives that reward volume over rigor:** publish-or-perish cultures encourage hasty submissions, salami slicing, p-hacking

Evidence of gaming and manipulation

- **Self-citation inflation:** Editors instruct authors to add citations to prior journal articles; documented by Clarivate investigations
- **Citation cartels:** Groups of researchers/journals agree to cite each other systematically to inflate metrics
- **Reviewer manipulation:** Reviewers with conflicts of interest (competitors) recommend rejection to suppress rivals
- **Predatory journals:** Low-/no-quality publishers accept almost everything for author fees (\$500–2,000); minimal/fake peer review
- **Paper mills:** Organizations sell fake authorship on fabricated papers
- **False indexing claims:** Journals claim Scopus/SCIE indexing when not indexed

Fact: Clarivate suppressed JIF for several journals in 2023 due to citation gaming. Check Beall's List (beallslist.net) for known predatory publishers and conferences.

What metrics don't measure

- **Rigor:** citation count $\neq$ correctness; flawed papers can be widely cited
- **Reproducibility:** no metric captures whether experimental results replicate or FEA models are properly converged
- **Engineering validity:** whether an experimentally derived correlation is valid outside the test range
- **Manufacturability and safety:** whether a new mechanism design is manufacturable, reliable, and safe in practice
- **Industrial impact:** whether a paper meaningfully influences standards (ASME, ISO), design codes, or industry guidelines
- **Null results:** negative findings (“method X does not work for condition Y”) are systematically undercited despite high value

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For mechanical engineering, real impact often appears in standards, design practices, and products—not only in citation counts.

Decision checklist: pick the output type

- 1 What is the **core contribution**? (new mechanical design / model / experimental method / dataset / synthesis / perspective)
- 2 What **evidence** is needed? (single proof-of-concept test vs full parametric study vs long-term durability tests vs field data)
- 3 What **artifact** must be usable? (CAD model, FE mesh, test rig design, dataset, MATLAB/Python code, experimental protocol)
- 4 What **reader action** do you want? (reuse a design, adopt a method, benchmark against your data, inform ASME/ISO standards, replicate experiments)
- 5 What is the **subfield culture**? (rotor dynamics vs manufacturing vs heat transfer vs vehicle systems vs materials processing)

Example: New correlation for boiling heat transfer in micro-channels → need extensive experimental data (multiple fluids, geometries, heat fluxes) and comparison with classical correlations (Kandlikar, Shah) → aim for full journal article in International Journal of Heat and Mass Transfer with supplementary datasets.

Decision checklist: pick the venue

- 1 **Scope fit:** Does the venue regularly publish work on your specific topic (e.g., gears, composites, fluid machinery, tribology)?
- 2 **Review expectations:** Does the venue expect experimental validation, mesh convergence studies, comparisons to ASME/ISO standards, and uncertainty analysis?
- 3 **Visibility:** Is the venue read by the mechanical engineering community and industry practitioners who matter for your topic?
- 4 **Indexing and quartile:** Is the journal indexed in Scopus (check SJR quartile) and/or Web of Science (SCIE)? What quartile in your specific ME subfield?
- 5 **Ethics and legitimacy:** Is the venue backed by a known society/publisher (ASME, IEEE, Elsevier, Springer) and free from predatory behavior (check COPE membership, Beall's List)?

Example: For a paper on vehicle dynamics control, journals like Vehicle System Dynamics (Q1 in Mechanical Engineering, Scopus + SCIE), International Journal of Vehicle Design, or IEEE Transactions on Vehicular Technology are more

Specific indicators to check

- **Journal:** Impact factor range (relative to field median; use Scimago for mechanical engineering rankings), **quartile (Q1/Q2 preferred)**, acceptance rate (if disclosed; typically 15–40%), time-to-decision (median: 3–8 months), indexing (Scopus + SCIE ideal), data/code policy, open access options
- **Conference:** Acceptance rate (check 3-year trend; is it stable or fluctuating?), review model (double-blind reduces bias), proceedings indexing (IEEE Xplore, Ei Compendex, Scopus = archival), standing organizers (same program committee > 3 years = stable reputation)
- **Publisher legitimacy:** COPE (Committee on Publication Ethics) member? Registered with DOAJ (if open access)? Member of scholarly societies (ASME, IEEE, SAE)? Transparent retraction policy?

Red flags: (1) Journal claims JIF but published < 2 years ago (JIF requires 2-year citation history). (2) Journal claims Q1 but not found in Scopus/JCR. (3) Conference changes name annually. (4) Unclear publisher address or contact information.

Ethical considerations in venue selection

- **Avoid predatory publishers:** Check Beall's List (beallslist.net), Scimago (journal rankings), Cabell's Predatory Reports
- **Disclose prior publication:** Reuse of figures, methods, or substantial text from prior work (your own or others') must be disclosed and cited
- **Respect funding embargoes:** If funded by NSF/DOE/EU, verify open-access compliance timing (typically 6–12 month embargo)
- **Choose transparent venues:** Reproducibility checklists, mandatory data/code release (or justification), post-publication correction policies (errata)
- **Consider equity:** Article Processing Charges (APCs) exclude researchers from low-income countries; consider Diamond OA venues (no author fees, no reader fees)

Guidance: Major mechanical engineering journals increasingly require data availability statements (experimental datasets, FEA meshes). Papers with shared data/code have 2× higher citation rates.

Takeaways

- **Output types** encode expected claims, evidence standards, and audience expectations (journal > conference > extended abstract in most ME subfields)
- **Conferences and extended abstracts** serve speed and rapid community feedback; journals provide archival permanence and comprehensive validation
- **Journal metrics, quartiles, and indexing** summarize historical patterns (citation behavior, selectivity) but do NOT measure engineering quality, safety, or industrial applicability
- **Quartiles (Q1–Q4)** provide field-specific rankings; aim for Q1/Q2 in your ME subfield for career advancement
- **Scopus and Web of Science (SCIE)** are gold standards for indexing; verify independently
- **Best practice:** use (metrics + quartile + indexing + scope fit + editorial standards + transparency + ethics + expert opinion) in combination, never in isolation
- **Recognize gaming:** self-citation inflation, citation cartels, predatory venues; always consult advisors, colleagues, and Beall's List